

THE SPIRITUAL BODY HAS NO FLESH, BONES, OR PHYSICAL SHAPE

A THEOLOGICAL NOTE ON THE DISTINCTION BETWEEN THE SPIRITUAL BODY AND THE EARTHLY RESURRECTION BODY

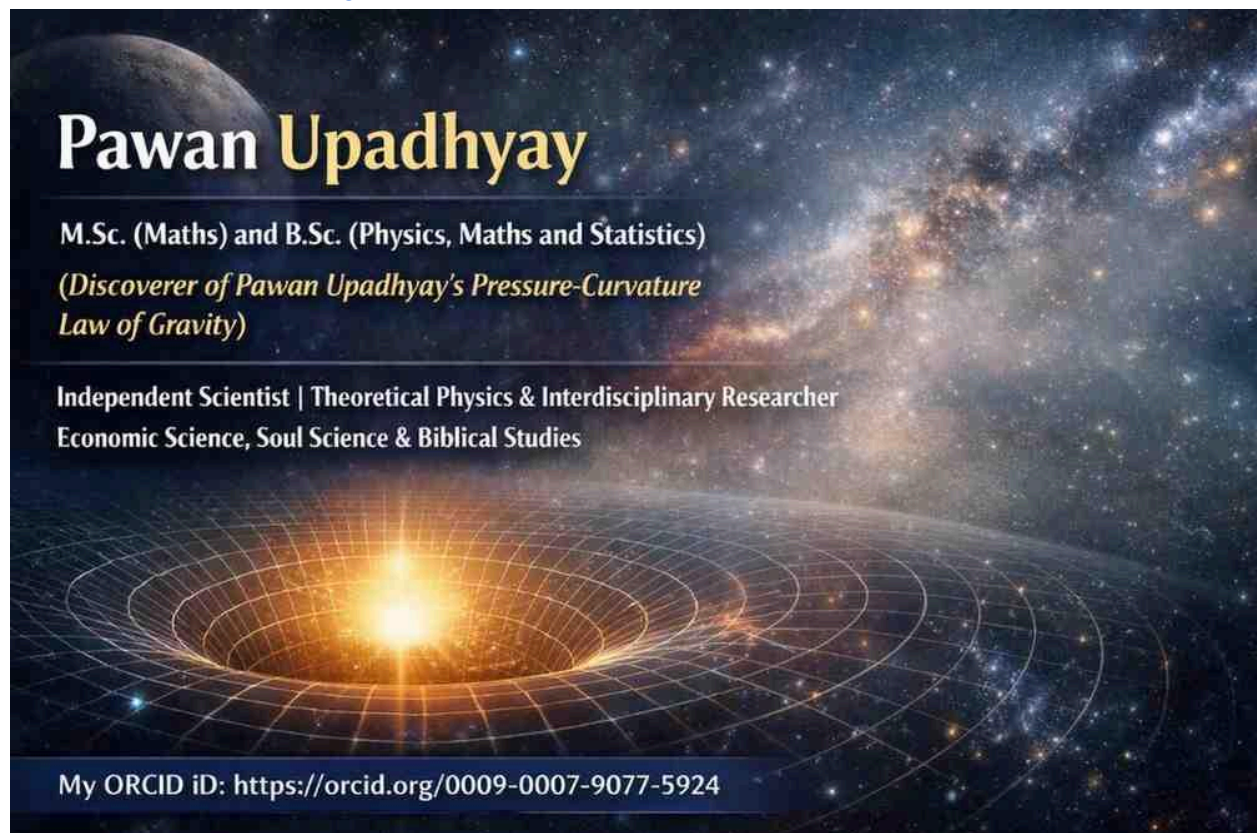
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ABSTRACT

This note presents an important clarification within Pawan Upadhyay's proposed theological model of the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. The spiritual body must be distinguished from the earthly body and from the resurrected earthly body.

According to the proposed model, the spiritual body is not composed of flesh or bones and does not possess a physical or anatomical shape. It should therefore not be imagined as an invisible, transparent, or ghost-like version of the earthly human body.

The term “spiritual body” is examined particularly in relation to the Greek expression σῶμα πνευματικόν (sōma pneumatikon), “spiritual body,” in 1 Corinthians 15:44. The note also considers Luke 24:39, where the risen Jesus says, “A spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have.” This passage provides an important distinction between spiritual existence and the flesh-and-bones bodily existence manifested by Jesus after His resurrection.

Within the proposed model, the expression “the spiritual body is in the image or likeness of the earthly body” does not mean that the spiritual body possesses the same physical shape, bones, flesh, dimensions, or anatomy as the earthly body. Rather, “image” or “likeness” refers to correspondence of personal identity.

Thus, the proposed model distinguishes between the spiritual body and the resurrected earthly body. The spiritual body is understood as a non-fleshly, non-bony, non-physical-shape mode of spiritual personal existence, while the resurrected body of Jesus is presented in the Gospel narratives as possessing flesh and bones.

The central proposition is:

SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ FLESH + BONES + PHYSICAL SHAPE

Instead:

SPIRITUAL BODY = SPIRITUAL MODE OF PERSONAL/BODILY EXISTENCE

1. INTRODUCTION

A precise distinction between the spiritual body and the earthly body is necessary for the development of Pawan Upadhyay’s proposed resurrection model.

The expression “spiritual body” can easily be misunderstood. A reader may imagine that a spiritual body is simply an invisible version of the physical human body, possessing the same head, arms, legs, bones, flesh, dimensions, and physical shape.

That is not the meaning proposed in this model.

The present note establishes the following distinction:

SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ EARTHLY BODY

and:

SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ FLESH AND BONES

and:

SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ PHYSICAL SHAPE

The spiritual body is instead understood as a spiritual mode of personal existence.

2. THREE DISTINCT BODILY CONCEPTS

The proposed model distinguishes three concepts.

First, the earthly body.

The earthly body is the physical human body consisting of flesh, bones, organs, and physical form.

Second, the spiritual body.

The spiritual body is proposed as a spiritual mode of personal existence without flesh, bones, or physical shape.

Third, the resurrected earthly body.

The resurrected earthly body is the earthly body raised from death and transformed into resurrection and glorified existence.

Therefore:

EARTHLY BODY ≠ SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ RESURRECTED BODY

These distinctions are essential.

3. THE EARTHLY BODY

The earthly body belongs to physical existence.

It possesses:

Flesh

Bones

Organs

Physical dimensions

Physical boundaries

Anatomical structure

Physical shape

Therefore:

EARTHLY BODY = PHYSICAL BODILY EXISTENCE

The earthly body can be seen, touched, measured, and described anatomically.

4. THE SPIRITUAL BODY

According to the proposed model, the spiritual body is fundamentally different.

It has:

No flesh

No bones

No physical organs

No physical dimensions

No anatomical structure

No physical shape

Therefore:

SPIRITUAL BODY $\neq$ PHYSICAL BODY

The spiritual body is not understood as a material object.

It is not proposed as a transparent human-shaped body.

It is not proposed as a ghost.

It is not proposed as an invisible physical duplicate.

Rather:

SPIRITUAL BODY = SPIRITUAL MODE OF PERSONAL EXISTENCE

5. NO FLESH IN THE SPIRITUAL BODY

The spiritual body, according to this model, does not consist of flesh.

Therefore:

SPIRITUAL BODY – FLESH

The flesh belongs to earthly bodily existence.

This distinction becomes especially important when discussing the resurrected Jesus, because the Gospel narratives describe His post-resurrection existence in terms of flesh and bones.

The spiritual body should therefore not be confused with the resurrected earthly body.

6. NO BONES IN THE SPIRITUAL BODY

The same principle applies to bones.

The spiritual body does not possess bones in the physical anatomical sense.

Therefore:

SPIRITUAL BODY $\neq$ BONES

and:

SPIRITUAL BODY $\neq$ FLESH + BONES

Bones are characteristics of physical bodily existence.

The spiritual body, as proposed here, is not anatomically structured.

7. NO PHYSICAL SHAPE

The third and equally important distinction is that the spiritual body does not possess physical shape.

A physical body can be described according to:

Length

Width

Height

Volume

Weight

Anatomical structure

Physical boundaries

A spiritual body, according to the proposed model, cannot be described in these physical terms.

Therefore:

SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ GEOMETRICALLY DEFINED BODY

There is no claim that the spiritual body has a human outline or anatomical form.

8. THE SPIRITUAL BODY IS NOT A GHOST

The concept should not be confused with the popular idea of a ghost.

A ghost is commonly imagined as an invisible or translucent human-shaped entity.

That is not the concept proposed here.

The proposed spiritual body is not:

INVISIBLE PHYSICAL HUMAN SHAPE

Instead:

SPIRITUAL BODY = NON-PHYSICAL SPIRITUAL MODE OF PERSONAL EXISTENCE

Consequently, the theory does not require us to imagine an invisible body having the same physical outline as the earthly body.

9. WHY USE THE WORD “BODY”?

A natural question arises:

If the spiritual body has no flesh, no bones, and no physical shape, why is it called a “body”?

Paul uses the expression:

σῶμα πνευματικόν

sōma pneumatikon

“spiritual body.”

The noun σῶμα (sōma) means “body.”

The adjective πνευματικόν (pneumatikon) means “spiritual.”

Therefore, Paul uses the expression:

SPIRITUAL + BODY

However, the precise metaphysical nature of the spiritual body is not fully explained by Paul.

Consequently, within this proposed model, “body” is not restricted to flesh, bones, and physical shape.

Instead, it refers to a spiritual mode of personal bodily existence.

10. SPIRITUAL BODY AND PERSONAL IDENTITY

The most important characteristic of the spiritual body within this model is personal identity.

The spiritual body corresponds to the person.

Therefore:

SPIRITUAL BODY ↔ PERSONAL IDENTITY

For Jesus Christ:

SPIRITUAL BODY ↔ IDENTITY OF JESUS CHRIST

This does not require the spiritual body to possess a physical human shape.

Personal identity and physical shape are not the same concept.

Therefore:

IDENTITY ≠ PHYSICAL SHAPE

11. THE MEANING OF “IMAGE”

The earlier proposition states:

“THE SPIRITUAL BODY IS IN THE IMAGE OR LIKENESS OF THE EARTHLY BODY.”

This statement requires clarification.

“Image” does not mean:

Same flesh

Same bones

Same organs

Same dimensions

Same physical shape

Same physical composition

Instead, in the proposed model:

IMAGE = IDENTITY + CORRESPONDENCE + LIKENESS

Therefore:

IMAGE/LIKENESS $\neq$ PHYSICAL SHAPE

The spiritual body corresponds to the earthly person without reproducing the physical anatomy of the earthly body.

12. SPIRITUAL BODY AND EARTHLY BODY

The relationship can therefore be represented:

EARTHLY BODY $\leftrightarrow$ SPIRITUAL BODY

But this does not mean:

EARTHLY SHAPE = SPIRITUAL SHAPE

There is no claim that the spiritual body possesses a physical shape.

The correspondence is primarily related to personal identity and continuity.

13. SPIRITUAL BODY AND RESURRECTION BODY

Another important distinction must be made between the spiritual body and the resurrected body.

The proposed model does not identify these two concepts as exactly the same.

The sequence is:

EARTHLY BODY $\downarrow$ PHYSICAL DEATH $\downarrow$ SPIRITUAL EXISTENCE $\downarrow$ RESURRECTION $\downarrow$
RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY

The spiritual body belongs to the proposed spiritual state.

The resurrected body belongs to the resurrection state.

Therefore:

SPIRITUAL BODY $\neq$ RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY

14. LUKE 24:39

Luke 24:39 records Jesus saying:

“A spirit does not have flesh and bones as you see that I have.”

This statement is extremely important for the present distinction.

Jesus identifies His resurrected condition as possessing flesh and bones.

Therefore:

RISEN JESUS = FLESH + BONES

within the Gospel's description of His resurrection appearance.

But according to the present theological model:

SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ FLESH + BONES

Therefore, Luke 24:39 should not be used to define the spiritual body as flesh-and-bones.

Instead, the verse establishes a distinction between a spirit and the bodily condition manifested by Jesus after His resurrection.

15. THE RESURRECTED JESUS

The resurrected Jesus is presented in the Gospel narratives as bodily recognizable.

He speaks to His disciples.

He allows Thomas to examine His wounds.

He demonstrates bodily reality.

He eats before His disciples.

These events concern the resurrection body of Jesus.

Therefore:

RESURRECTED JESUS = BODILY RESURRECTION

The present model distinguishes this from the proposed spiritual-body state preceding the resurrection.

16. THE WOUNDS OF CHRIST

John 20 presents the wounds of Jesus as part of the recognition of the risen Christ.

Thomas encounters the same Jesus who had been crucified.

The important principle is:

CRUCIFIED JESUS → RISEN JESUS

The identity remains continuous.

However, bodily condition has changed.

Therefore:

SAME IDENTITY + TRANSFORMED BODILY CONDITION

This supports the distinction between identity and physical form.

17. SPIRITUAL BODY AND IDENTITY

The proposed spiritual-body model therefore emphasizes:

The spiritual body does not require physical shape.

The spiritual body does not require flesh.

The spiritual body does not require bones.

The spiritual body does not require physical dimensions.

Nevertheless, it remains associated with the identity of the person.

Thus:

SPIRITUAL BODY = SPIRITUAL PERSONAL CONTINUITY

within the proposed model.

18. THE PROPOSED STATE OF CHRIST DURING PHYSICAL DEATH

According to Pawan Upadhyay's proposed model, when Christ's earthly body died:

EARTHLY BODY → PHYSICAL DEATH

the Divine Spirit did not cease to exist.

The model proposes:

DIVINE SPIRIT + SPIRITUAL BODY

as the continuing spiritual state.

The spiritual body in this model has:

No flesh

No bones

No physical shape

No physical dimensions

The spiritual body is instead understood as corresponding to the identity of Christ.

19. RESURRECTION AS A TRANSITION

The proposed model therefore understands resurrection as a transition from spiritual existence to resurrected bodily existence.

The sequence is:

PHYSICAL DEATH ↓ SPIRITUAL EXISTENCE ↓ RESURRECTION ↓ RESURRECTED
EARTHLY BODY ↓ GLORIFIED EXISTENCE

This distinguishes the spiritual body from the resurrected body.

20. THE RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY

The resurrected earthly body is different from the proposed spiritual body.

The resurrected Jesus is described as having flesh and bones.

Therefore:

RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY = FLESH + BONES + BODILY FORM

while:

SPIRITUAL BODY = NO FLESH + NO BONES + NO PHYSICAL SHAPE

This distinction is fundamental to the theory.

21. TWO MODES OF BODILY EXISTENCE

The model therefore proposes two different modes.

SPIRITUAL MODE:

Divine Spirit + Spiritual Body

Characteristics:

No flesh

No bones

No physical shape

No anatomical structure

Spiritual existence

Personal identity

EARTHLY/RESURRECTION MODE:

Divine Life + Resurrected Earthly Body

Characteristics:

Flesh

Bones

Bodily form

Recognizable identity

Resurrection existence

Glorification

22. THE IMAGE PRINCIPLE REDEFINED

The proposition that the spiritual body is “in the image” of the earthly body must therefore be stated carefully.

It does not mean:

“The spiritual body looks physically identical to the earthly body.”

Instead:

“The spiritual body corresponds to the personal identity represented by the earthly body.”

Therefore:

IMAGE = PERSONAL CORRESPONDENCE

rather than:

IMAGE = PHYSICAL DUPLICATION

23. MATHEMATICAL DESCRIPTION OF THE DISTINCTION

A physical body can be described using physical quantities:

$$V = L \times W \times H$$

where:

L = length

W = width

H = height

V = physical volume

The proposed spiritual body is not being defined through these quantities.

Therefore:

SPIRITUAL BODY $\neq$ VOLUME

SPIRITUAL BODY $\neq$ PHYSICAL DIMENSIONS

SPIRITUAL BODY $\neq$ GEOMETRICAL SHAPE

This reinforces the distinction between spiritual and physical bodily existence.

24. THE SPIRITUAL BODY IS NOT A MATERIAL OBJECT

Within this model:

SPIRITUAL BODY $\neq$ MATERIAL OBJECT

It is not proposed as something that can be weighed, measured, dissected, or anatomically described.

Therefore, scientific physical measurements cannot presently define the spiritual body.

The concept belongs to theological and metaphysical discussion rather than ordinary physical anatomy.

25. RELATION TO 1 CORINTHIANS 15

Paul's expression:

σῶμα πνευματικόν

“spiritual body”

remains central.

However, the exact metaphysical nature of the spiritual body is not fully explained.

Paul describes resurrection transformation but does not provide a physical anatomy of the spiritual body.

Therefore, the present model proposes that the spiritual body should not be imagined as a flesh-and-bones object.

26. BIBLICAL DATA AND THEOLOGICAL HYPOTHESIS

The following distinction is necessary.

Explicit biblical teaching includes:

Jesus died.

Jesus was buried.

Jesus was raised.

Jesus appeared to His disciples.

Jesus demonstrated bodily reality after resurrection.

Jesus spoke of flesh and bones.

Paul speaks of a spiritual body.

Paul speaks of the image of the earthly and heavenly.

The following are theological hypotheses of the present model:

Christ possessed a spiritual body during physical death.

The spiritual body contained no flesh.

The spiritual body contained no bones.

The spiritual body had no physical shape.

The spiritual body corresponded to Christ's earthly personal identity.

The resurrection involved the transition from spiritual existence to resurrected earthly bodily existence.

These propositions should therefore be identified as part of the proposed theological framework.

27. THE CENTRAL DISTINCTION

The central distinction can be summarized:

EARTHLY BODY:

Flesh + Bones + Physical Shape

SPIRITUAL BODY:

No Flesh + No Bones + No Physical Shape

RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY:

Flesh + Bones + Transformed/Glorified Bodily Existence

Therefore:

SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ EARTHLY BODY

and:

SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY

28. THE COMPLETE MODEL

The proposed model can be expressed:

DIVINE SPIRIT + EARTHLY BODY ↓ INCARNATE CHRIST

EARTHLY BODY ↓ PHYSICAL DEATH

DIVINE SPIRIT + SPIRITUAL BODY ↓ SPIRITUAL EXISTENCE

SPIRITUAL EXISTENCE ↓ RESURRECTION

RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY + DIVINE LIFE ↓ GLORIFIED CHRIST

29. MASTER FORMULA

The complete theological model is:

DIVINE SPIRIT + SPIRITUAL BODY + EARTHLY BODY → RESURRECTED CHRIST

But the three dimensions are not identical.

Therefore:

SPIRIT ≠ SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ EARTHLY BODY

And:

SPIRITUAL BODY ≠ FLESH + BONES + PHYSICAL SHAPE

The relationship of image is:

SPIRITUAL BODY ~ PERSONAL IDENTITY OF EARTHLY BODY

where “~” means correspondence or likeness.

30. CONCLUSION

The distinction between the spiritual body and the earthly resurrection body is essential for a precise formulation of Pawan Upadhyay's proposed theological model.

The spiritual body is not understood as flesh.

It is not understood as bones.

It is not understood as an anatomical structure.

It is not understood as possessing physical dimensions.

It is not understood as having a human-shaped physical outline.

It is not understood as a ghost or transparent physical duplicate of the earthly body.

Instead, the spiritual body is proposed as a spiritual mode of personal existence that corresponds to the identity of the earthly person.

Therefore:

SPIRITUAL BODY = SPIRITUAL PERSONAL/BODILY EXISTENCE

while:

RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY = FLESH + BONES + TRANSFORMED BODILY EXISTENCE

The statement that the spiritual body is “in the image or likeness of the earthly body” should consequently be understood as referring to **identity and correspondence**, not physical shape.

The central distinction is:

SPIRITUAL BODY = NO FLESH = NO BONES = NO PHYSICAL SHAPE

whereas the risen Jesus is presented in Luke 24:39 as possessing flesh and bones.

Therefore, within the proposed model, the spiritual body and the resurrected earthly body represent two distinct modes of existence.

The proposed sequence is:

EARTHLY BODY → PHYSICAL DEATH → SPIRITUAL EXISTENCE → RESURRECTION →
RESURRECTED EARTHLY BODY → GLORIFIED EXISTENCE

The central theological proposition is:

“THE SPIRITUAL BODY HAS NO FLESH, NO BONES, AND NO PHYSICAL SHAPE; ITS
RELATIONSHIP TO THE EARTHLY BODY IS ONE OF PERSONAL IDENTITY AND
CORRESPONDENCE, NOT PHYSICAL FORM.”

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